Nehru made clear in a letter to Kennedy in August 1963 that India would require more. He reiterated that China was a geopolitical and ideological threat—alone and in combination with Pakistan—and stressed that Beijing would not stop until it either forced a political settlement upon India or caused its internal disintegration. This challenge required an Indian effort on both the defense and development fronts. The US had helped "handsomely and generously," but India had much left to do. If the government did not take adequate measures, it would have to submit to China and would lose its citizens' confidence. Thus the government could not meet the American demands to limit or reduce its defense expenditures.[87]

In November, the Indian prime minister once again wrote to Kennedy, asking for deliveries of equipment to be expedited. He highlighted how Chinese forces were continuing to pose a threat. And in that context, he expressed concern about overtures to Beijing from Britain and France, among other European countries, as well as Japan. He warned that their offers to supply China equipment and technology "dictated by the lure of short-term political gains or commercial profits" would create a "serious" problem.[88]

### *A Lost Opportunity?*

In November, Bowles discussed with the president a proposal for a five-year military assistance program for India, preferably with $65 million to $75 million of annual aid. Komer was skeptical of the administration's ability to put aid on a long-term basis or commit to more than the $50 million of annual aid that the Defense Department had been envisioning. Nevertheless, he said that if the president decided to propose a long-term agreement to India, "why not see how much we can use this leverage to get some things from Delhi that we really want?"[89] Before Kennedy could make a decision, however, he was assassinated.

Bowles later implied that had the president lived, India and the US would have had a much closer relationship as a result of greater military assistance.[90] Was there a lost opportunity? As the ambassador himself admitted, before Kennedy's death, there was only "tentative" agreement on a five-year military package even from the Indian government.[91] Bowles contended that, despite State Department concerns, Kennedy "left no doubt